

Design tokens — taxonomy, schema & theming

Design tokens — taxonomy, schema & theming

Revision: 1 Last modified: 2026-06-25T12:00:00Z

Master technical specification — Volume 10 (Design System), nano-detail deep-dive. This document **owns** the canonical **design-token taxonomy** and the **JSON source-of-truth schema** for HelixVPN's own design system: the three token tiers (primitive → semantic → component), the naming convention, the full token categories (color, typography, spacing, radius, elevation/ shadow, motion, z-index, breakpoints) with **light + dark value pairs**, the theming-resolution model (theme × platform × brand), and the drift / contract rules that keep every emitted form (JSON / CSS / Dart / SwiftUI / Compose / ArkTS / C-Qt) byte-faithful to this one source.

SPEC-ONLY. It describes *what the tokens are* and *how they resolve* — not the shipping `helix_design` build. The concrete hex values of the color tier are defined and contrast-proven in the sibling [color-system.md](#); this document defines the **structure** the colors live in (and reproduces the load-bearing hexes so the schema samples are valid, never placeholder).

Position. `helix_design` is a **fully decoupled, reusable submodule** (`vasic-digital/helix_design`, `snake_case` flat per §11.4.28/.29/.74) that configures **OpenDesign** (the mandatory token/theme engine, §11.4.162) to emit these tokens. This doc owns the *token model*; the OpenDesign integration mechanics live in `[opendesign-foundation.md]`, the multi-form emit in `[token-export-pipeline.md]`, the colors in `[color-system.md]`, type/icon/ motion detail in `[typography-iconography-motion.md]`.

Boundary with sibling docs. This doc **owns** the schema + tier rules + naming. It **consumes**: the 7-variant connection-state vocabulary from the FFI surface [v04-client/ffi-surface.md §3.2] (the TunnelStatus the component tier's connection tokens map onto); the 3-app / 8-platform matrix from the spine [SPECIFICATION.md §3]; the OpenDesign engine contract [opendesign-foundation.md].

Evidence base. [04_CLIENT §N] = final/03-client-core-and-ui.md; [FFI §N] = final/v04-client/ffi-surface.md; [SPINE §N] = final/SPECIFICATION.md; [COLOR §N] = final/v10-design/color-system.md. Claims not grounded in the evidence base or in this document's own original design choices are tagged UNVERIFIED per constitution §11.4.6 — never fabricated. The token taxonomy itself is **original HelixVPN design work** (no external source needed), modeled on the well-established primitive/semantic/component three-tier pattern.

Table of contents

- 0. Why tokens, and the one-source rule
 - 1. The three tiers
 - 2. Naming convention
 - 3. The JSON source-of-truth schema
 - 4. A concrete, valid token sample (all categories, light+dark)
 - 5. The theming-resolution model (theme × platform × brand)
 - 6. Scales — spacing, radius, elevation, motion, z-index, breakpoints
 - 7. Component tokens — referencing semantic, never primitive
 - 8. The connection-state component tokens (the FFI seam)
 - 9. Drift, contract & validation rules
 - 10. Surfaced decisions & cross-doc contracts
 - Sources verified
-

0. Why tokens, and the one-source rule

A **design token** is a named, platform-neutral key bound to a design value (a color, a length, a duration, a font axis). HelixVPN ships **three apps** (Client, Console, Connector) across **eight platforms** (iOS, macOS, Android, Windows, Linux, Web, HarmonyOS, Aurora) from one Flutter UI core [SPINE §3]. Without a single token source, that surface drifts: the iOS connect button greens one way, the Web one another, and the "connected" colour stops *meaning* "connected".

The one-source rule. There is exactly **one** authored source of truth — a set of JSON token files in `helix_design/tokens/**` — and **every** consumable form (CSS custom properties, Dart ThemeData, SwiftUI Color/Font, Compose ColorScheme/Typography, ArkTS resource maps, C/Qt `.qml/header` constants) is **generated** from it (`[token-export-pipeline.md]`). A hand-edited platform theme is a **drift defect** (§9), the visual analogue of the schema-first zero-drift principle the rest of HelixVPN already enforces for proto/OpenAPI [SPINE §4 principle 8].

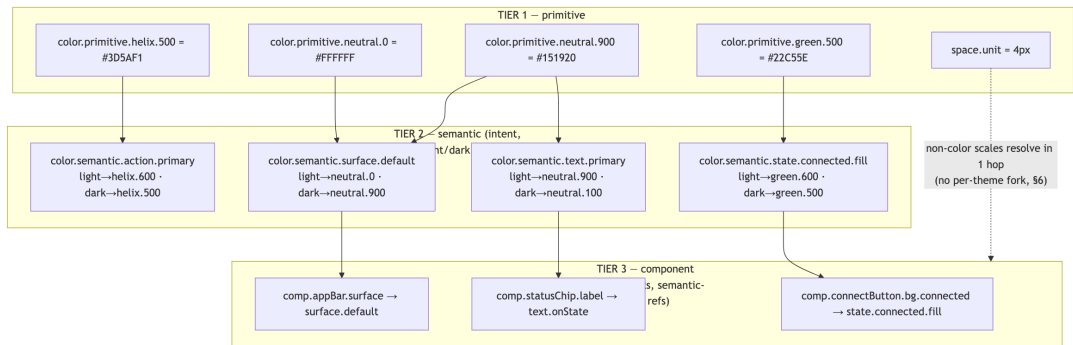
Honest boundary (§11.4.6). Tokens guarantee *consistency and single-sourcing* of design values — they do **not** by themselves guarantee usability, accessibility, or correct layout. Contrast is proven in `[color-system.md]`; no-overlap / no-label-overlay layout is a component + visual-regression concern (`[component-library.md]`, `[visual-regression-and-qa.md]`, §11.4.162). This doc owns the values' *structure*, not their *fitness*.

1. The three tiers

Tokens resolve through **exactly three tiers**, each referencing only the tier below it. This is the load-bearing rule that lets a single brand or theme swap ripple correctly through every component.

Tier	Purpose	References	May a component use it directly?	Example
Primitive (a.k.a. <i>global / core</i>)	The raw palette + raw scale. Theme-agnostic, brand-agnostic. A flat dictionary of literal values.	nothing (literals only)	No	<code>color.primitive.helix.500 = #3D5A68</code>
Semantic (a.k.a. <i>alias / system</i>)	Intent. Names a <i>role</i> ("the default surface", "primary")	primitive (per theme)	Discouraged — allowed for one-off bespoke surfaces, but components	<code>color.semantic.surface.default = {light: helix-neutral.0, dark: helix-neutral.900}</code>

Tier	Purpose	References	May a component use it directly?	Example
Component	text", "the danger colour") and binds it per theme to a primitive. This is the only tier with light/dark forks.		should prefer a component token	
	A specific UI part's specific slot. Names the exact widget property.	semantic only (never primitive)	Yes — this is what widgets read	<code>comp.connectButton.bg.connected</code> <code>color.semantic.state.connected</code>



Why component → semantic only (never component → primitive). If `comp.connectButton.bg.connected` pointed straight at `green.500`, a brand or theme change would have to rewrite every component token. Routing through `state.connected.fill` means the theme swap touches **one** semantic binding and every component that references it updates for free. A component token that references a primitive is a **tier violation** caught by the lint in §9.

2. Naming convention

Every token id is a **dot-delimited, lowercase, snake-free camelCase-segment** path. The **first segment is the category**, the **second is the tier**, the rest narrows to the leaf. (camelCase *within* a segment; dots *between* segments — this survives every target language's identifier rules and the OpenDesign engine input.)

<category>.<tier>.<group>[.<subgroup>...].<leaf>[.<state|variant>]

Part	Closed/ open	Values
category	closed	color · font · space · radius · elevation · motion · z · breakpoint · border · opacity · size
tier	closed	primitive · semantic · (component uses the comp. root, below)
group	open	per category (helix, neutral, green for color-primitive; surface, text, state, action, border for color-semantic; ...)
leaf	open	the terminal name (500, default, primary, connected)
state/ variant	open, optional	hover · pressed · disabled · focus · fill · onFill · subtle

Component tokens use a distinct root, comp, so a grep cleanly separates the widget tier:

comp.<componentName>.<slot>[.<state|variant>]

2.1 Canonical examples

color.primitive.helix.500	# raw brand blue	→
#3D5AF1		
color.primitive.neutral.0	# raw white	→
#FFFFFF		
color.primitive.green.500	# raw connected-green	→
#22C55E		
color.semantic.surface.default (light/dark)	# the default surface role	
color.semantic.text.primary (light/dark)	# primary text role	
color.semantic.state.connected.fill	# the "connected" fill role	
(light/dark)		
color.semantic.action.primary (light/dark)	# primary action role	
comp.connectButton.bg.connected	# the connect button's bg when	
Connected		

```

comp.connectButton.bg.disconnected # ...when Disconnected
comp.statusChip.label               # the status-chip text slot
comp.exitPicker.row.selected.bg     # selected exit row background
font.semantic.body.md               # body medium type role
space.scale.4                       # 4 × base = 16px
radius.scale.md                     # medium corner radius
elevation.semantic.menu              # the elevated-menu shadow role
motion.semantic.connectPulse.dur    # the connecting-pulse duration
z.semantic.modal                    # modal stacking layer
breakpoint.scale.md                 # the medium responsive
breakpoint

```

Naming invariants (lint-enforced, §9). (a) every id starts with a closed category; (b) every non-comp id has a closed tier second segment; (c) comp.* ids reference only *.semantic.* values; (d) ids are unique across the whole tree; (e) ids never collide with a target-language reserved word after the JSON→identifier transform (the transform replaces .→_/- per form; see [token-export-pipeline.md]).

3. The JSON source-of-truth schema

The source is a tree of JSON files (one file per category is the recommended layout; the loader merges them). Every **leaf token object** has a fixed shape — a **Style-Dictionary-class** \$value/\$type envelope extended with HelixVPN's **per-theme fork** for color-and-other-themed categories.

3.1 The leaf-token envelope

```

// the shape of EVERY leaf token (primitive or semantic or
// component)
{
  "$type": "color",                // closed: color|dimension|
  fontFamily|fontWeight|           //          number|duration|
  cubicBezier|shadow|zIndex
  "$value": <literal | { "light": <ref|literal>, "dark": <ref|
  literal> } | <ref>>,
  "$description": "human-readable intent (REQUIRED on every
  semantic token)",
  "$extensions": {                 // optional engine/consumer
  hints
    "helix.deprecated": false,
    "helix.allyMin": "AA",         // contrast floor this token
    is contractually held to ($COLOR)
    "helix.platforms": ["*"]       // or a subset; "*" = all 8

```

```
}
}
```

- **Reference syntax** — a `$value` of the form `"{color.primitive.helix.500}"` is a **reference** to another token (curly-brace, dotted path). The resolver (OpenDesign / the export pipeline) dereferences it. A reference **MUST** resolve to a token of the **same \$type**.
- **Per-theme fork** — only the **themed categories** (color, elevation/shadow, and the small set of border/opacity tokens that differ by theme) carry a `{ "light": ..., "dark": ... }` object in `$value`. **Non-themed categories** (space, radius, font metrics, motion, z, breakpoint) carry a single literal/reference — they are identical across themes (§6).
- **Primitive \$value** is always a **literal** (never a reference) — primitives are the leaves the references terminate at.
- **Semantic \$value** is the **per-theme fork**, each side a **reference to a primitive**.
- **Component \$value** is a **single reference to a semantic token** (no fork — the fork already happened one tier down, so a component token is theme-correct by construction).

3.2 \$type closed vocabulary → target-form mapping

\$type	JSON literal form	CSS	Dart	S
color	"#RRGGBB" / "#RRGGBBAA"	--c: #...	Color(0xAARRGGBB)	C
dimension	"16px" / "1.5rem"	16px	16.0 (logical px)	1
fontFamily	"Inter"	font-family	fontFamily	F
fontWeight	400/600	400	FontWeight.w400	.
number	1.5	unitless	double	C
duration	"180ms"	180ms	Duration(ms:180)	0
cubicBezier	[0.2,0,0,1]	cubic-bezier(...)	Cubic(...)	.
shadow	{offsetX,offsetY,blur,spread,color}	box-shadow	BoxShadow	.
zIndex	integer	z-index	int	z

UNVERIFIED — the exact ArkTS resource-map key syntax and the C/Qt .qml/header emit shapes are pinned by the export-pipeline contract test ([token-export-pipeline.md] §drift-gate); the column above states the *intended* mapping, frozen there. Marked UNVERIFIED until that contract test exists per §11.4.6.

4. A concrete, valid token sample (all categories, light+dark)

The following is a **valid, self-consistent** slice of the source tree (not a placeholder) covering every category. Color literals match [color-system.md]; non-color scales are defined in §6 of this doc.

```
// helix_design/tokens/primitive.json - TIER 1 (literals, theme-agnostic)
{
  "color": { "primitive": {
    "helix": { "500": { "$type": "color", "$value": "#3D5AF1" },
              "600": { "$type": "color", "$value": "#2F47C4" },
              "400": { "$type": "color", "$value":
"#6B86FB" } },
    "neutral": { "0": { "$type": "color", "$value": "#FFFFFF" },
                 "100": { "$type": "color", "$value": "#EDEFF3" },
                 "500": { "$type": "color", "$value": "#6B7385" },
                 "600": { "$type": "color", "$value": "#4B5263" },
                 "900": { "$type": "color", "$value":
"#151920" } },
    "green": { "500": { "$type": "color", "$value": "#22C55E" },
              "600": { "$type": "color", "$value":
"#15803D" } },
    "amber": { "500": { "$type": "color", "$value": "#F59E0B" },
              "700": { "$type": "color", "$value":
"#B45309" } },
    "orange": { "600": { "$type": "color", "$value":
"#C2410C" } },
    "red": { "600": { "$type": "color", "$value":
"#DC2626" } },
    "teal": { "500": { "$type": "color", "$value": "#14B8A6" },
             "700": { "$type": "color", "$value":
"#0F766E" } }
  } },
  "space": { "primitive": { "unit": { "$type": "dimension",
"$value": "4px" } } },
  "font": { "primitive": {
    "family": { "sans": { "$type": "fontFamily", "$value":
"Inter" },
               "mono": { "$type": "fontFamily", "$value":
"JetBrains Mono" } },
    "weight": { "regular": { "$type": "fontWeight", "$value":
400 },
               "medium": { "$type": "fontWeight", "$value":
500 },
               "semibold": { "$type": "fontWeight", "$value":
600 } }
  } }
}
```



```
// helix_design/tokens/semantic.json – TIER 2 (intent, light/dark
fork)
{
  "color": { "semantic": {
    "surface": {
      "default": { "$type": "color", "$description": "the base app
surface",
      "$value": { "light": "{color.primitive.neutral.0}",
        "dark": "{color.primitive.neutral.900}" },
      "$extensions": { "helix.allyMin": "AAA" } },
      "raised": { "$type": "color", "$description": "cards/sheets
above the base",
      "$value": { "light": "#F7F8FA", "dark": "#222732" } }
    },
    "text": {
      "primary": { "$type": "color", "$description": "default
body/heading text",
      "$value": { "light": "{color.primitive.neutral.900}",
        "dark": "{color.primitive.neutral.100}" },
      "$extensions": { "helix.allyMin": "AAA" } },
      "secondary": { "$type": "color", "$description": "supporting
text",
      "$value": { "light": "{color.primitive.neutral.600}",
        "dark": "#C2C8D4" } },
      "onState": { "$type": "color", "$description": "label
drawn ON a filled state colour",
      "$value": { "light": "#FFFFFF", "dark": "#FFFFFF" } }
    },
    "action": {
      "primary": { "$type": "color", "$description": "primary
action/brand fill",
      "$value": { "light": "{color.primitive.helix.600}",
        "dark": "{color.primitive.helix.500}" },
      "$extensions": { "helix.allyMin": "AA" } }
    },
    "state": {
      "connected": { "fill": { "$type": "color", "$description":
"the Connected state colour",
      "$value": { "light": "{color.primitive.green.600}",
        "dark": "{color.primitive.green.500}" } } },
      "connecting": { "fill": { "$type": "color", "$description":
"Connecting/Handshaking/Reconnecting",
      "$value": { "light": "{color.primitive.amber.700}",
        "dark": "#FBBF24" } } },
      "danger": { "fill": { "$type": "color", "$description":
"Danger (leak/killswitch)",
      "$value": { "light": "{color.primitive.red.600}", "dark":
"#F87171" } } }
    },
    "border": {
      "default": { "$type": "color", "$value": { "light":
"#DCE0E8", "dark": "#353B49" } }
    }
  } },
}
```

```

    "font": { "semantic": {
      "body": { "md": { "$type": "number", "$description": "body
medium size (px)",
        "$value": 14 } },
      "heading": { "lg": { "$type": "number", "$value": 22 } }
    } }
  }
}

```

// helix_design/tokens/component.json – TIER 3 (widget slots, semantic-only refs)

```

{
  "comp": {
    "connectButton": {
      "bg": {
        "connected": { "$type": "color", "$value":
"{color.semantic.state.connected.fill}" },
        "connecting": { "$type": "color", "$value":
"{color.semantic.state.connecting.fill}" },
        "disconnected": { "$type": "color", "$value":
"{color.semantic.action.primary}" },
        "danger": { "$type": "color", "$value":
"{color.semantic.state.danger.fill}" }
      },
      "label": { "$type": "color", "$value":
"{color.semantic.text.onState}" },
      "radius": { "$type": "dimension", "$value":
"{radius.scale.full}" }
    },
    "statusChip": {
      "label": { "$type": "color", "$value":
"{color.semantic.text.onState}" },
      "padX": { "$type": "dimension", "$value":
"{space.scale.3}" }
    },
    "appBar": { "surface": { "$type": "color", "$value":
"{color.semantic.surface.default}" } }
  }
}

```

// helix_design/tokens/scale.json – non-themed scales (single literal, §6)

```

{
  "space": { "scale": { "1":
{"$type":"dimension","$value":"4px"}, "2":
{"$type":"dimension","$value":"8px"},
    "3":
{"$type":"dimension","$value":"12px"}, "4":
{"$type":"dimension","$value":"16px"},
    "5":
{"$type":"dimension","$value":"24px"}, "6":
{"$type":"dimension","$value":"32px"} } },
  "radius": { "scale": { "sm":
{"$type":"dimension","$value":"4px"}, "md":
{"$type":"dimension","$value":"8px"},

```

```

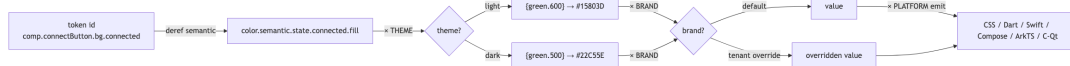
      "lg":
{"$type":"dimension","$value":"16px"},"full":
{"$type":"dimension","$value":"9999px"} } },
    "elevation": { "semantic": {
      "card": { "$type": "shadow", "$value": {
        "light":
{ "offsetX":"0px","offsetY":"1px","blur":"3px","spread":"0px","color":"#f5f5f5"},
        "dark":
{ "offsetX":"0px","offsetY":"1px","blur":"3px","spread":"0px","color":"#000000"} },
      "menu": { "$type": "shadow", "$value": {
        "light":
{ "offsetX":"0px","offsetY":"8px","blur":"24px","spread":"-4px","color":"#f5f5f5"},
        "dark":
{ "offsetX":"0px","offsetY":"8px","blur":"24px","spread":"-4px","color":"#000000"} },
      "motion": { "semantic": {
        "connectPulse": { "dur":
{"$type":"duration","$value":"1200ms"},
          "ease": {"$type":"cubicBezier","$value":
[0.4,0,0.6,1]} },
        "stateXfade": { "dur":
{"$type":"duration","$value":"180ms"},
          "ease": {"$type":"cubicBezier","$value":
[0.2,0,0,1]} } } },
      "z": { "semantic": { "base":{"$type":"zIndex","$value":0},
"nav":{"$type":"zIndex","$value":100},
          "overlay":{"$type":"zIndex","$value":1000},
"modal":{"$type":"zIndex","$value":1100},
          "toast":{"$type":"zIndex","$value":1200},
"danger":{"$type":"zIndex","$value":2000} } },
      "breakpoint": { "scale": { "sm":
{"$type":"dimension","$value":"360px"},
        "md":
{"$type":"dimension","$value":"600px"},
        "lg":
{"$type":"dimension","$value":"1024px"},
        "xl":
{"$type":"dimension","$value":"1440px"} } }
    }

```

Every \$value above is a real, resolvable value or a real reference into the primitive/semantic trees in this same sample — **no placeholders, no TODO** (§11.4.6). The 8-hex colors (e.g. #1519201A) are #RRGGBBAA — neutral.900 at ~10 % alpha for the light-card shadow.

5. The theming-resolution model (theme × platform × brand)

A token id resolves to a **concrete value** along **three axes**. Resolution is deterministic and total (every (id, theme, platform, brand) yields exactly one value or a build error — never a silent default, §11.4.6).



5.1 Axis 1 — theme (light / dark) — mandatory both

Every **semantic** color/elevation token **MUST** define **both** light and dark (§9 gate CM-token-light-dark-complete). A semantic token missing a theme side is a build-blocking defect (§11.4.162 mandates light+dark for every component). Because components reference semantics, **every component token is dual-theme by construction** — no component ever declares a theme fork itself.

The active theme is chosen at runtime by the app (system setting → user override → forced-by-context, e.g. Danger never changes theme but always paints from the danger semantic). The Flutter helix-ui builds **two ThemeData** (light + dark) from the emitted Dart and hands both to MaterialApp(theme:, darkTheme:) [04_CLIENT §7].

5.2 Axis 2 — platform (emit target) — form, not value

Platform does **not** change a token's *value*; it changes its *emitted form* (§3.2 table) and, rarely, its *adaptation* (e.g. a platform that lacks a shadow primitive renders elevation as a hairline border). A token may opt out of a platform via \$extensions.helix.platforms; the export pipeline omits it from that form's output. **Platform never forks \$value** — that would re-introduce drift. Per-platform *look-and-feel* adaptation (Material vs Cupertino vs desktop vs TV-leanback vs HarmonyOS vs Aurora) is a **component-mapping** concern owned by [platform-adaptation.md], built **on top of** these identical token values.

5.3 Axis 3 — brand (tenant / app accent) — override map

The default brand is **HelixVPN** (the helix.* ramp). The model supports a **brand-override layer**: a thin JSON that re-points a *small, closed* set of semantic tokens (chiefly action.primary and the app-accent) to a different primitive ramp, leaving the connection-state and feedback semantics **fixed** (state colours **MUST** stay stable across brands — "connected" is always green, a multi-tenant Console must not recolour safety semantics). The per-app

accent differentiation (Client vs Console vs Connector) is one such override and is specified in [color-system.md §per-app accent]. Resolution order: **brand-override (if present) → semantic default → primitive**.

D-DT-1 (surfaced, §10). The closed set of brand-overridable semantic tokens is {action.primary, accent.*, surface.brandTint}. Allowing a tenant to override state.* or feedback.* is **rejected** (safety-colour drift). If a future product needs per-tenant state colours, that is a §11.4.66 operator decision, not a silent capability.

6. Scales — spacing, radius, elevation, motion, z-index, breakpoints

The non-color scales are **theme-agnostic** (one value, no light/dark fork) — except **elevation/shadow**, whose *color* differs by theme (a shadow is darker and more opaque on dark surfaces, §4 sample).

6.1 Spacing — 4-pt base scale

space.primitive.unit = 4px. The scale is integer multiples; component padding/ gaps reference **scale steps**, never raw px.

token	multiplier	value	typical use
space.scale.0	0	0px	reset
space.scale.1	1×	4px	icon-to-label gap
space.scale.2	2×	8px	tight intra-component
space.scale.3	3×	12px	chip padding
space.scale.4	4×	16px	default content padding
space.scale.5	6×	24px	section gap
space.scale.6	8×	32px	screen margin (phone)
space.scale.7	12×	48px	hero / connect-button ring
space.scale.8	16×	64px	large desktop gutter

The 4-pt base is the original HelixVPN choice; it aligns with the 8 platforms' common density grids (Material 4dp/8dp, Cupertino 8pt) so one scale maps cleanly everywhere.

6.2 Radius scale

token	value	use
radius.scale.none	0px	data tables
radius.scale.sm	4px	inputs, chips
radius.scale.md	8px	cards, sheets
radius.scale.lg	16px	dialogs, the connect panel
radius.scale.full	9999px	the circular ConnectButton, status dots, pills

6.3 Elevation / shadow scale (themed color)

token	light shadow	dark shadow	use
elevation.semantic.flat	none	none	base surface
elevation.semantic.card	0 1px 3px #1519201A	0 1px 3px #00000066	cards, list rows
elevation.semantic.menu	0 8px 24px #15192026	0 8px 24px #00000080	menus, popovers
elevation.semantic.modal	0 16px 48px #15192033	0 16px 48px #000000A6	dialogs, sheets

The **shape** (offset/blur/spread) is theme-invariant; only the **shadow color + alpha** forks — darker, more opaque on dark (a soft light-grey shadow is invisible on a dark surface). This is the only non-color category that forks by theme.

6.4 Motion tokens

token	value	use
motion.semantic.stateXfade.dur	180ms	cross-fade between two TunnelStatus colours
motion.semantic.stateXfade.ease	cubic-bezier(0.2,0,0,1)	(decelerate)
motion.semantic.connectPulse.dur	1200ms	the Connecting/Reconnecting amber pulse loop

token	value	use
motion.semantic.connectPulse.ease	cubic-bezier(0.4,0,0.6,1)	(ease-in-out, symmetric loop)
motion.semantic.press.dur	100ms	button press scale/ink
motion.semantic.sheet.dur	240ms	sheet/dialog enter
motion.semantic.reducedMotion	0ms	the value all *.dur collapse to when the OS "reduce motion" flag is set (a11y; the Reconnecting "pulse" becomes a static amber, never a flash)

Reduce-motion contract. When the platform reports reduced-motion, the export/runtime substitutes motion.semantic.reducedMotion for animation durations. The Reconnecting state therefore degrades from *pulse* to *static amber* — it never strobes (a11y + the §11.4.107 no-flash discipline).

6.5 Z-index scale

base 0 → nav 100 → overlay 1000 → modal 1100 → toast 1200 → danger 2000. The **danger layer (2000) sits above everything** so a Danger banner (leak / kill-switch tripped) is never occluded by a modal or toast — the safety state always wins the stacking order (mirrors the FFI rule that Danger overrides all intent [FFI §3.2/§3.3]).

6.6 Breakpoints

token	min-width	layout class
breakpoint.scale.sm	360px	compact phone
breakpoint.scale.md	600px	large phone / small tablet — two-pane begins

token	min-width	layout class
breakpoint.scale.lg	1024px	tablet / desktop — Console master-detail
breakpoint.scale.xl	1440px	wide desktop — Console three-pane

The Client app is primarily sm/md; the Console (web + desktop) uses lg/xl; the same tokens serve TV-leanback (treated as xl with larger touch/ focus targets). Responsive screen specs live in [screens-client.md] / [screens-console.md].

7. Component tokens — referencing semantic, never primitive

A component token names **one widget's one slot in one state**. It is the only tier widgets read. Example: the ConnectButton's background across its states maps **one-to-one** onto the connection-state semantics (the FFI seam, §8).

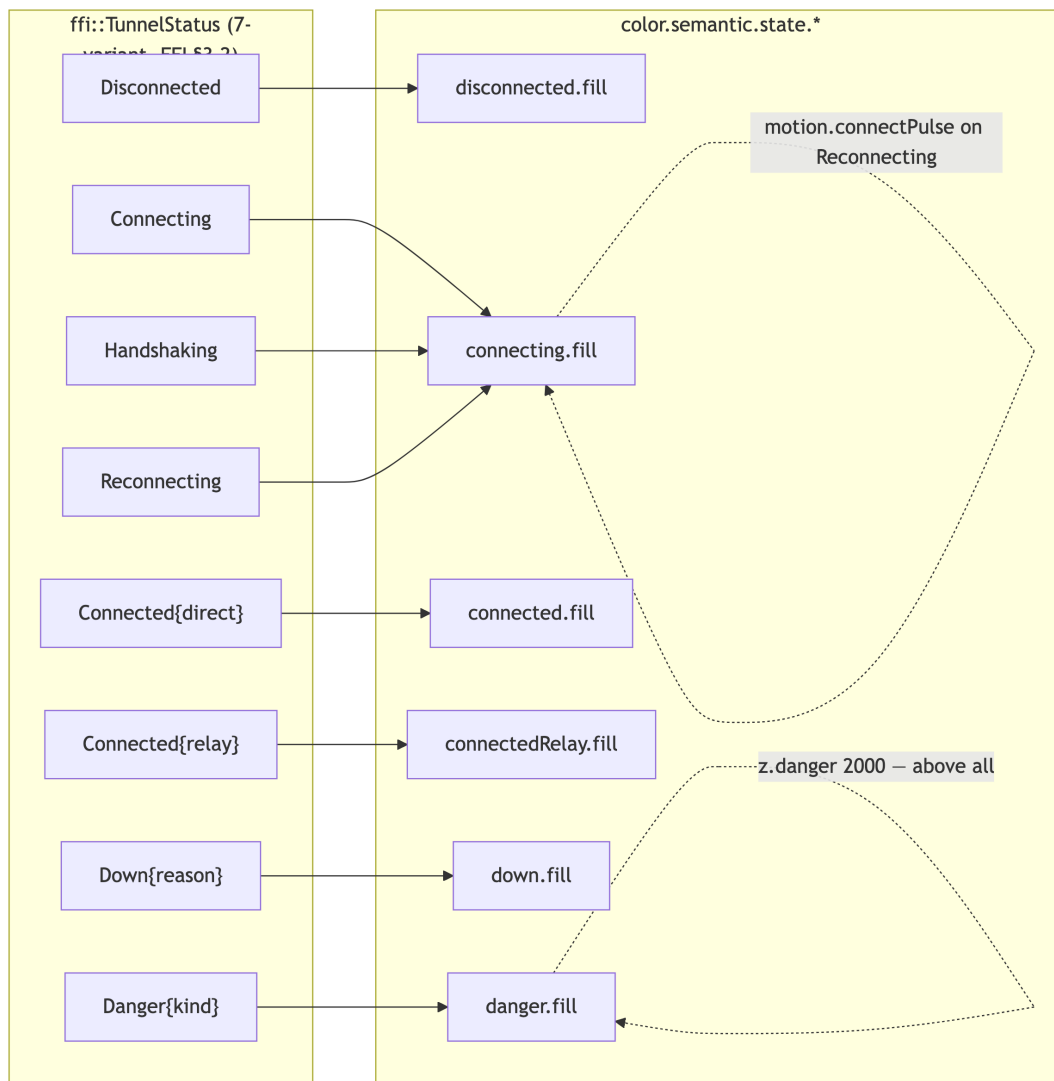
```
"comp": { "connectButton": {
  "bg": {
    "disconnected": { "$value":
"{color.semantic.action.primary}" },      // brand idle
    "connecting": { "$value":
"{color.semantic.state.connecting.fill}" },
    "handshaking": { "$value":
"{color.semantic.state.connecting.fill}" },
    "connected": { "$value":
"{color.semantic.state.connected.fill}" },
    "reconnecting": { "$value":
"{color.semantic.state.connecting.fill}" },
    "down": { "$value":
"{color.semantic.state.down.fill}" },
    "danger": { "$value":
"{color.semantic.state.danger.fill}" }
  },
  "label": { "$value":
"{color.semantic.text.onState}" },          // white on every
fill
  "ring": { "$value":
"{color.semantic.state.connected.glow}" },  // the "connected"
halo
  "radius": { "$value": "{radius.scale.full}" },
  "size": { "$value": "{size.connectButton.diameter}" }
} }
```


The rule restated: **every comp.* \$value is a single reference into *.semantic.*** (color/elevation) or into a non-themed *.scale.*. A comp.* token that references a *.primitive.* value or hard-codes a literal is a **tier violation** (§9 lint). This is what makes a brand or theme swap a one-tier edit.

8. The connection-state component tokens (the FFI seam)

The single most product-specific token group: the connection-state colours map **exactly** onto the **7-variant ffi::TunnelStatus** the UI switches on [FFI §3.2]. This document owns the *token structure*; [color-system.md] owns the *hex values + contrast proofs*. The mapping is **total** — every one of the seven variants has a dedicated semantic + component token, so the UI never invents a colour for a state (§11.4.6).

ffi::TunnelStatus variant	semantic token	component token (Component background)
Disconnected	color.semantic.state.disconnected.fill	comp.connectButton.bg (= action.primary background)
Connecting	color.semantic.state.connecting.fill	comp.connectButton.bg
Handshaking	color.semantic.state.connecting.fill (shared with Connecting)	...bg.handshaking
Connected { path:"direct" }	color.semantic.state.connected.fill	...bg.connected
Connected { path:"relay" }	color.semantic.state.connectedRelay.fill	...bg.connectedRelay
Reconnecting	color.semantic.state.connecting.fill (amber, pulsing via motion.connectPulse)	...bg.reconnecting
Down { reason }	color.semantic.state.down.fill	...bg.down
Danger { kind }	color.semantic.state.danger.fill	...bg.danger



- **Direct vs relay sub-shade.** `Connected.path` is "direct" (P2P) or "relay" (DERP-style) [FFI §3.2]. Two distinct *green* semantics (`connected.fill` vs `connectedRelay.fill`) let the StatusChip show the path without changing the "I am protected = green" signal. Hexes in [color-system.md].
- **Reconnecting = amber pulse, not a new colour.** It reuses `connecting.fill` + `motion.connectPulse`; reduce-motion degrades it to static amber (§6.4).
- **Danger overrides intent.** The Danger family is red **and** sits on z-layer danger (2000) — it can never be hidden, mirroring the FFI projector rule that Danger overrides every other state [FFI §3.3].

9. Drift, contract & validation rules

Tokens are only single-source if **machine-checked**. The following gates run in `helix_design` CI and the consuming `helix-ui` pre-build (paired §1.1 mutation each):

Gate	Asserts	Mutation that must FAIL it
CM-token-tiers-valid	every id starts with a closed category; non-comp ids carry a closed tier; comp.* ids reference only *.semantic.*/*.scale.* (never primitive, never literal)	point a comp.* \$value at color.primitive.*
CM-token-light-dark-complete	every semantic color/elevation token defines both light and dark	delete the dark side of surface.default
CM-token-refs-resolve	every {...} reference resolves to an existing token of the same \$type	reference a non-existent / wrong-type token
CM-token-ids-unique	no duplicate id across the whole tree	duplicate color.primitive.helix.500
CM-token-a11y-floor	every token carrying helix.a11yMin meets its floor against its paired surface (computed, [COLOR \$contrast])	drop text.primary to a value below its AAA floor
CM-token-no-drift	every emitted form (CSS/Dart/Swift/Compose/ArkTS/C-Qt) re-generates byte-identically from the JSON source; a hand-edited emitted file is a finding ([token-export-pipeline.md])	hand-edit helix_tokens.dart
CM-token-state-coverage	all 7 ffi::TunnelStatus variants (§8) have a semantic + component token	remove state.danger.fill

The drift gate is the load-bearing one. It is the visual analogue of HelixVPN's proto/OpenAPI zero-drift principle [SPINE §4.8]: the only way a platform theme can diverge from the source is a hand-edit, and the gate catches that hand-edit. Emitted forms are **never** authored, only generated ([token-export-pipeline.md]); exported docs of the token reference carry the §11.4.65/.168 visual-validation per [visual-regression-and-qa.md].

10. Surfaced decisions & cross-doc contracts

id	Decision / contract	Status
D-DT-1	Closed brand-overridable semantic set = {action.primary, accent.*, surface.brandTint}; state.* / feedback.* are NOT brand-overridable (safety-colour stability). Widening requires a §11.4.66 operator decision.	recommended, surfaced
D-DT-2	Per-theme fork lives only on color, elevation (+ a tiny border/opacity set). All other categories are theme-invariant single values.	decided
D-DT-3	Component tokens reference semantic only ; the lint (CM-token-tiers-valid) enforces it.	decided
C-DT-A (consumes)	The 7-variant ffi::TunnelStatus vocabulary is owned by [FFI §3.2]; §8's token set MUST stay total over it (gate CM-token-state-coverage). A new FFI variant is a contract change here.	contract
C-DT-B (provides)	This schema (§3) is the input contract for [token-export-pipeline.md] (the emit) and [color-system.md] (the color values + contrast).	contract
C-DT-C (provides)	The naming convention (§2) is the identifier contract every emitted form's transform must honor.	contract
U-DT-1 UNVERIFIED	Exact ArkTS resource-map key syntax + C/Qt emit shapes (§3.2) — pinned by the export-pipeline contract test; UNVERIFIED until that test exists.	open

Sources verified

- **Token taxonomy, tier model, naming, theming model, scales, drift rules — NO external source needed — original HelixVPN design work**, modeled on the well-established primitive→semantic→component three-tier token pattern and the Style-Dictionary \$value/\$type envelope convention (engine-neutral;

the concrete engine is OpenDesign per §11.4.162, integration in [opendesign-foundation.md]).

- **7-variant ffi::TunnelStatus vocabulary (§8)** — final/v04-client/ffi-surface.md §3.2 (read 2026-06-25). The token set is held total over it by gate CM-token-state-coverage.
- **3-app / 8-platform matrix, schema-first zero-drift principle (§0, §5)** — final/SPECIFICATION.md §3, §4 (read 2026-06-25).
- **Color hex values reproduced in the JSON samples (§4)** — defined + contrast-proven in final/v10-design/color-system.md (this doc reproduces only the load-bearing subset to keep the samples valid).
- **WCAG contrast floors referenced by helix.allyMin** — W3C WCAG 2.1 SC 1.4.3 / 1.4.6 and the relative-luminance formula (<https://www.w3.org/TR/WCAG21/#dfn-relative-luminance>); the arithmetic is performed in [color-system.md].
- Items explicitly marked UNVERIFIED (U-DT-1) are pending their named contract test per §11.4.6 — not asserted as fact.